

The background of the entire page is a complex, organic marbled paper pattern. It features swirling, wavy, and cellular shapes in various shades of brown, tan, and cream, creating a rich, textured visual field.

Carlos Irijalba

Endotic
FFWD>>
Strange Stranger
Gowanus
Pahoehoe

Skins
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High Tides

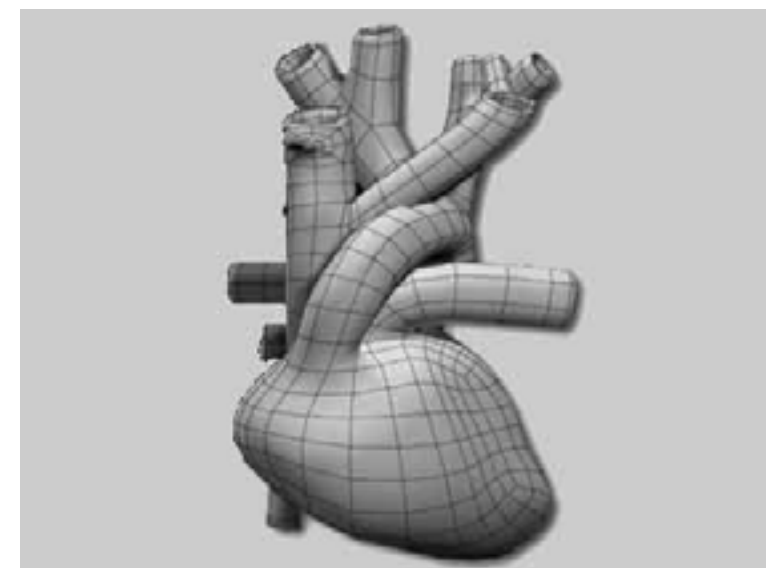
Endotic

"A beaver's DNA doesn't stop expressing itself at the end of its whiskers, but at the edge of its dam," writes the ecological theorist Timothy Morton. What if the physics of entropy were sliding between humans and objects as pure inertia? What if an engine's exhaust pipe- the part that directs smoke from the guts of the car to the outside- as a piece of engineering owes its nature to an organic order imprinted on the entrails of its creator? What is the relationship between a glottis and a meander, between a city and a puddle?

In the context of this second solo exhibition by Carlos Irijalba with the gallery, the endotic points to the interrelations between the human being and his environment. There is no difference between human and nature, between inside and outside. Language separates us but the exotic is within ourselves.

Like the objects and structures that we produce, an important part of our constitution, as multicellular mammals, is formed by carbon. These objects carry with them biological designs that we can interpret as unconscious secretions, or unformed traces, that are fluid and open to unforeseen evolution. Genetic material duplicates and mutates not only at the biological level, but also within the strategies and tools with which we, *consciously*, shape a new landscape.

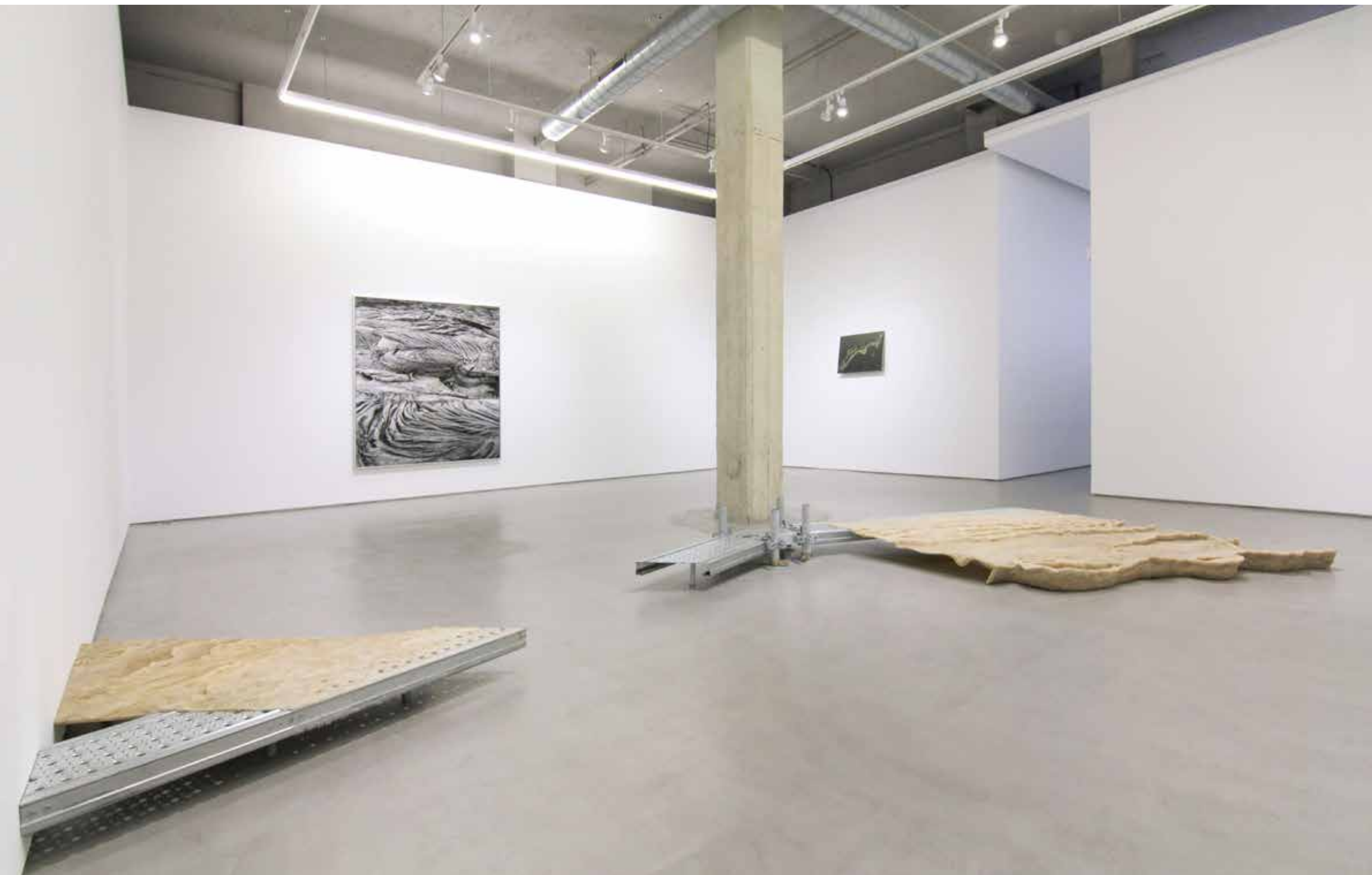
These parallel dynamics are not obvious; they happen at different rhythms and scales. This exhibition highlights the convergence of those dissonances as a means to approach the transitory states of matter. We observe the solid, liquid, and gaseous states as relative and symptomatic of the heterogeneous interrelations between what's tangible or intangible, fertile or sterile, and the blurry lines between what is animate and what is inert.









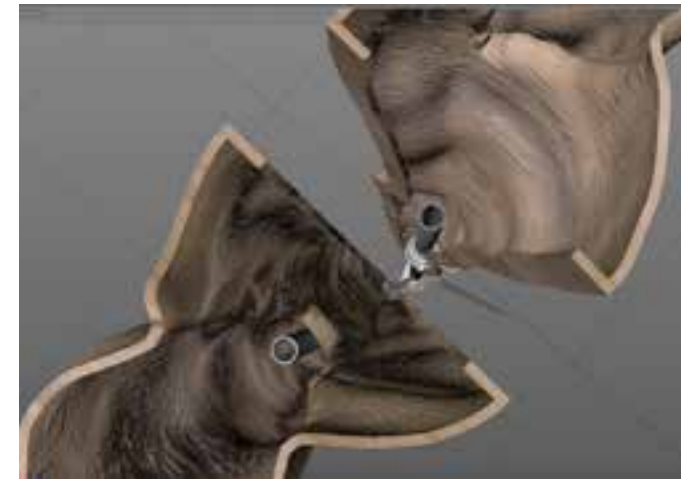
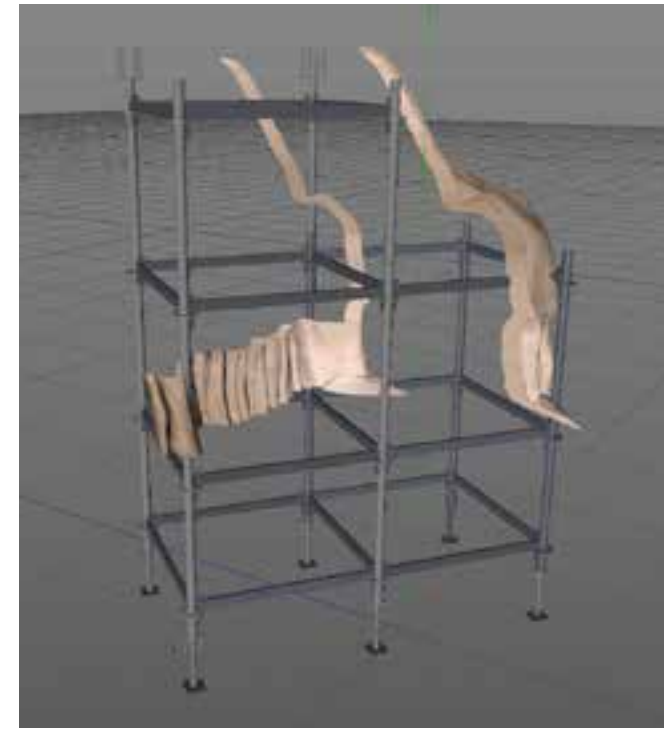




FFWD >>

presents a study on human intervention, a kind of pole vault in time between locus and technè. The Chauvet cave paintings were made 32.000 years ago in the Monts d'Ardeche region in France and discovered by speleologists in 1994. The cave was closed to the public shortly afterwards for preservation and study. The only material contribution that modern humans made to this environment is a scaffolding footbridge to protect the interior of the cave from germs and bacteria.

In collaboration with Atelier Phenomenes in Paris (the company commissioned by the French government in 2016 to make a replica of the Chauvet Cave's natural dynamics), Irijalba created a projection of what will happen to this footbridge 32.000 years from now, when rimstone dams (stalagmite-like horizontal calcareous deposits) have assimilated the structure, in turn becoming a time continuum.







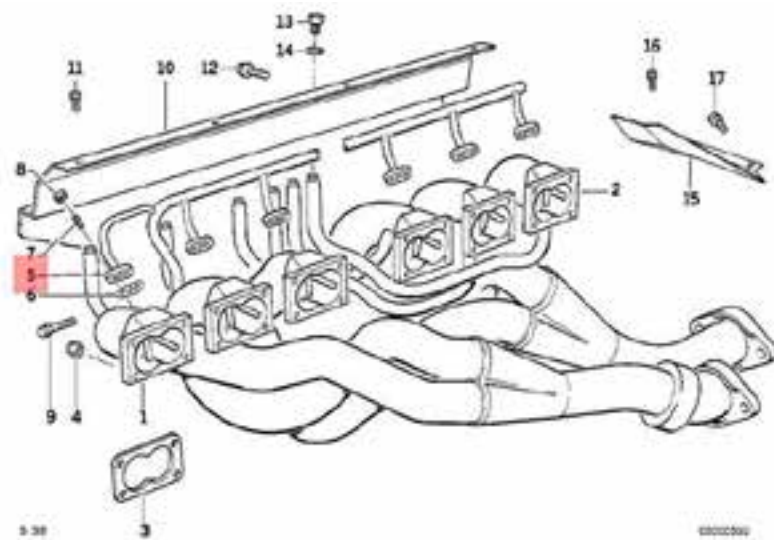




Strange stranger

explores the biomimetic patterns visible in the industrial processes that replicate structures inscribed in our evolutionary trace.

We witness phenomenological echoes in the objects that we fabricate, but how far is a cell from the tissue that it makes up? We label these qualities as inert, but in fact they belong to our own nature, even if we are not conscious of it. To call this relationship biomimesis proves to be limiting and reductionist. The reference is not exogenous, but endogenous. Our actions and productions appeal to the endotic, and this makes us responsible for the spaces that these objects occupy, the functions they perform, the time they last and the trace they leave behind.









Gowanus

This series takes its name from the Gowanus Canal in Brooklyn which is thought to be named after a Native American chief from the Canarsee tribe, the inhabitants of that land before the Dutch and the English.

The Canal serves nowadays as industrial ship dock and many car paint shops pour turpentine spills on their waters. With the low tide, the spills draw the coming and going traces of ships and tides as two different systems that never blend.









Pahohoe

The Hawaiian term *pahoehoe* means “smooth lava” in its solid state, and it entails the most abstract and visually explicit manifestation of the Earth’s core’s material reaction in the face of a sudden contrast in temperature.

When the recent eruption of Kilauea volcano happened in the spring of 2018, I visited the Big Island in Hawaii to experience on a 1:1 scale the earth turning inside out. Guided by the US military along with a group of scientists, we visited ground zero of the eruption. This was an experience that was impossible to translate into images. As the lava activity subsided, I spent the following weeks walking through the Kalapana Estate areas, to encounter the contradiction between flowing lava matter and its crystallization into solid state.



Pahohoe is matter's most spontaneous expression and the most immediate visualization of the chemical reactions that comprise it. The characteristic behavior of lava illustrates, at both micro and macro levels, processes that pertain to fields like meteorology, linguistics, economy, and genetics, where properties that are equally creative and destructive are made visible. When *pahoehoe* finally cools and crystallizes, it displays a strange quality of frozen time. As the philosopher Reza Negarestani says, lava makes evident “decomposition as a constructive process.” The simultaneous destruction and creation of territory in Hawaii and its repetitive pattern reveal the grammatology of our planet and how the surface of this system that we inhabit is coded.











Skins

At the height of the Spanish economic crisis in 2010 I visited a company in Madrid producing three dimensional replicas that in five years went from appearing in Science magazine to making porexpan hearts for fake wedding cakes.

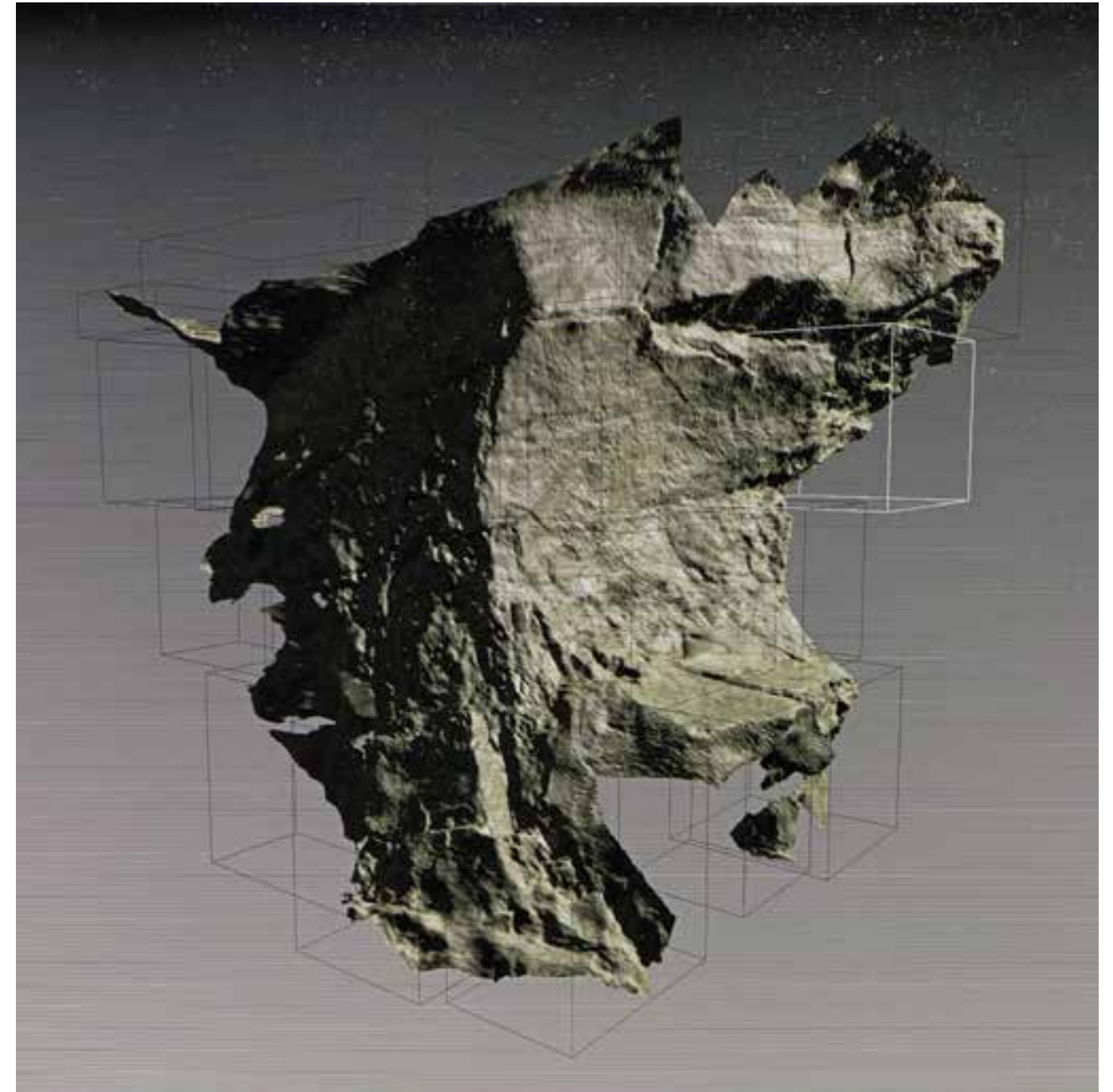
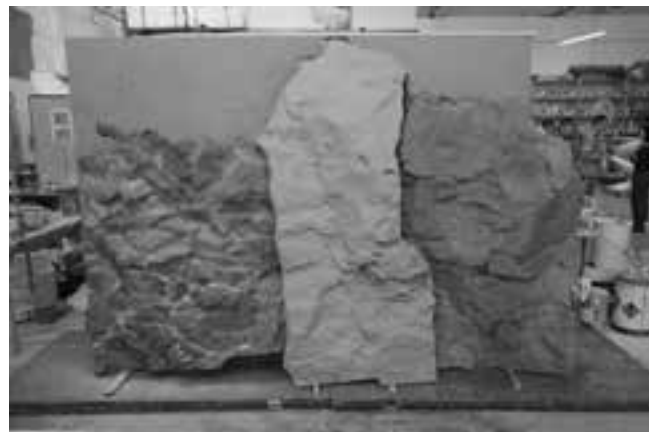
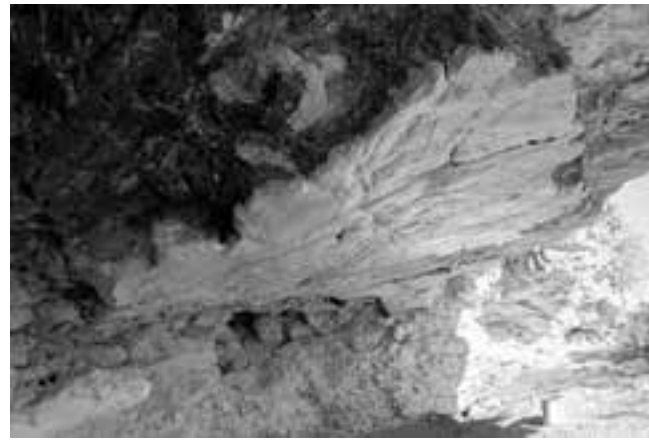
They had taken part in the fabrication of replicas of several caves from the Cantabrian coast in the late 1990's. During the spanish economic bubble, the company was in charge of scanning, to the highest quality at that time, several cave paintings that were soon to be closed to the public.

The cave walls sheltered humans from the extreme meteorological conditions of the Upper Paleolithic. Now, 13.000 years after the caves were occupied, conditions have changed. Rising temperatures and mild climatic conditions allowed 7,000 millions humans beings to inhabit every remote corner of the planet.

Nomads turned sedentary, hunting turned into leisure, and magic into spectacle. Humans switched from active to pasive and masses were driven from one place to another. Visitors come in thousands as well to every place that's now a site, and their breath carries biological potentials longing for existence as well.

The cave wall was always there, unaware of other temporalities.

Then scans were made to reproduce the cave surfaces and prevent them from being damaged, as they had become allergic to humans. The replicas of some of them became museums, places where visitors could exhale on some other real, and spread out in gift shops and restaurants.



Other scanned cave surfaces were not so crucial for the Eurocentric narrative construction and were therefore not reproduced. When the company went bankrupt along with the whole Spanish economy, the scans entered a standby period, saved as digital data. The scanned 3D files were saved on Zip drives, a floppy disc which seemed to be the ultimate storage format in the 90's but became outdated in the 00's; by the 10's we could hardly find any readers for them.

So here we are in front of a scan from an inaccessible wall, recorded in an unreadable format as some kind of digital archeology. Every translation involves a loss. When our only reference is a low-fi digital interpretation, it seems like we attend to an industrial metabolism of magnifying losses.

Politics of the replica.

The notion of replica is crucial for the western fictional construction of space and time. As with amusement parks or World Expos, in cave replicas distances and waiting times are heightened and fragmented in order to fit a comprehensible experience and keep up attention and excitement. Reality is too vast for our participatory rhythms, shaped by the culture of music singles or video compilations.

As Bataille noted, the Lascaux cave "participate[s] in the spirit of the festival overflowing the world of work, necessary for the protection of this world". The excuse of protection led to the closure of the real cave and the production of the replica. In every translation there is always an interpretation.

The politics that permit a reduction of life cycles into artificial rhythms have powerful implications. Opposite to natural cycles like the seasons or natural light times, the fictionalization of people's experience and the use of confected temporalities to have established productive fictions like electoral cycles or working days and weekends. The politics of the replica, as we will call it, help to reduce history into comprehensible terms and interpretations. The visitor wants to believe, so the visit to the replica legitimizes other fictions and multiples.

Economic development implies overproduction and superfluity. The time reserved for leisure is a crucial ingredient of consumer society as leisure itself becomes a major source of business. Crisis demands editing and measuring the object's relevance. The positive aspect of systemic crises provokes drastic editing.

Elastic history.

History is written by those in possession of language and the tools of expression. Taking this one step further, after Walter Benjamin, the next logical step in a validated history, depends on the ability to reproduce and spread narration.

The Eurocentric construction of reality and its ability to authenticate and overwhelm the world with its version of history is provoked by the capacity to overwrite others—that is, by symbolic overload.

A clear example is furnished by recent cave discoveries in Indonesia. Found in the 1980's there was no rush to date them, and once they were dated were proven to be 40.000 years old. There was no rush to make this public, especially when the new replica of Chauvet in France is about to be inaugurated in 2016 with an investment of 60 million euros.

This leads us again to the Eurocentric or Franco-Hispanocentric perspective, revealing how history also erases history using capacities to set up a standard or to dictate what is pre- or post- in relation to sanctioned measurement.

Exercise of the unnecessary.

The works in *Skins* address notions of surface, the superficiality of time and constructs of relevance and necessity. They lean physically on the phenomena and technology involved in the replica.

The scanning technology used in the '90s reproduce the cave in a manner redolent of the technological horizon of that time. Is through technology that the visual is engineered, and we only know the visible contingencies of the past through the defined interventions of particular technologies of the present.

In the beginning we mentioned an "industrial metabolism of magnifying losses". Here we suggest a constructive use of that loss. We acknowledge that the 3D scanner (unlike human vision) sees no image. It's a selective eye, that touches with ultrasound waves, not with light. It just reads form and volume. X-Y-Z. The scanner used in those caves read the same naked volume that these prehumans confronted. No color, no representation, no magic symbolism. Just raw, connotation-free-cave-skin; but yes, with a delay. The delay of techne, the same one that brought them to foreground.

The result is a file that has no depth, and no cultural information. An interpretation enslaved by its time, a time of exponential mutations.

After that file what has happened is a production of the cave surfaces by the same procedure, companies and workers that took part in the production of Altamira cave and others. *Skins* uses the language and imperfections of the replica not to hide its structure, but to make it transparent and bring the walls to a stage prior to human intervention. They refuse to represent anything but themselves.

They are just fragments of a larger totality, edited by historical chance. It's not a rewind or a fast forward, its more reformatting that wall information into a real previous to representation, liberating them from the historical, political and cultural weight acquired through time.

There is no restoration possible, for any restoration is a new object. These pieces deal with that finiteness of the replica by reformatting the wall skins on an exercise of the unnecessary.

They constitute the timeline of a surface in relation to self-reflective anthropocentrism. The contemporary time-cut of the replica, especially its simulated resolution, represents a technological temporality. Entropy and acceleration merge with quantity and overload. We bear witness to a viral dimension of the ontological exercise through which our place in the universe is decentered.











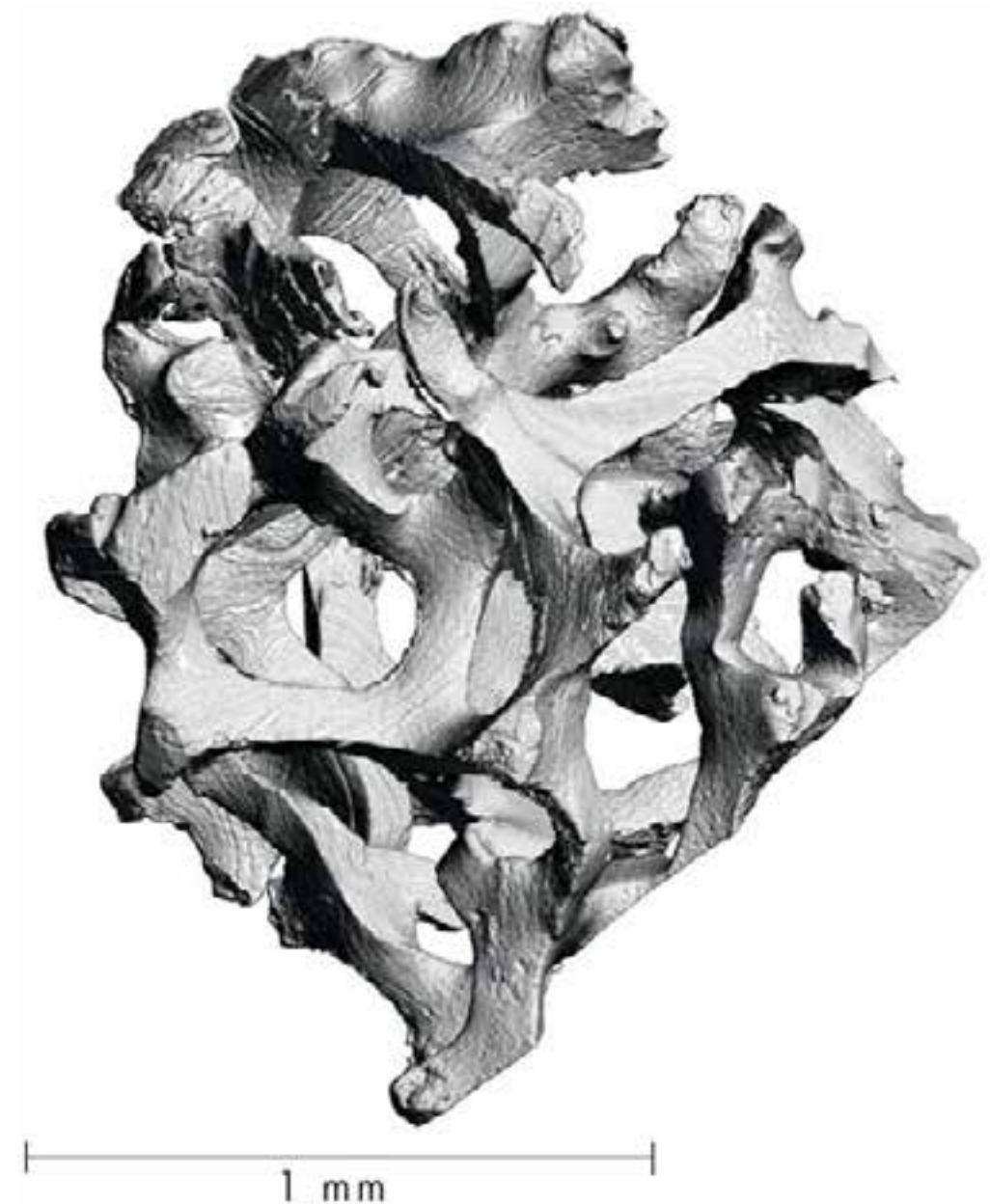


Muscle memory

The first application for metal foam was for human prosthesis, as it has the same structure as bone. First the medical field sought to apply the new material to bettering the quality of human life. The dynamic market around the automotive industry later adapted the metal foam, now informed by a much sharper vector of commodification.

A new material inducts a reaction within the industrial organism, acting as a catalyst. A metabolism based on profits synthesizes material applications in the same way a body processes sugar, for example. The industrial organism does not distinguish between social stratifications.

These pieces of metal foam deal with the notion of industrial prosthesis and the socio-economic structures that formed them. As a way to deflate the industrial structure appropriated from nature, technology gets redigested by culture.













Zechstein

Flowing is not a unique quality of the liquid, and liquid does not only flow. Matter and biomass are subject to a combination of flows and critical points of intensity. They manifest as such in relation to our space/time perspective.

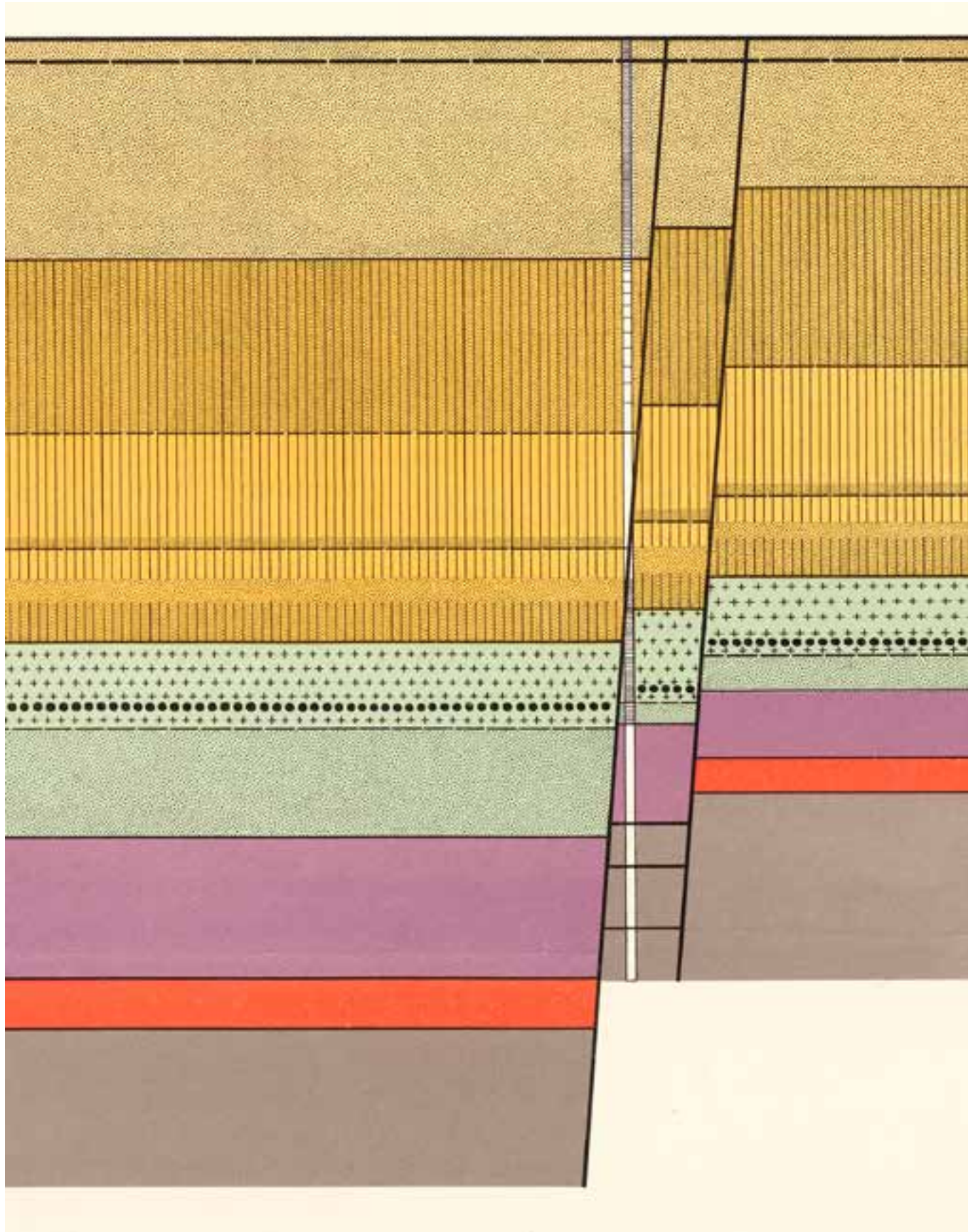
Particularly this last approach led to the Zechstein Sea body of work (2014-2017) which was developed in the Netherlands, where I use geological procedures and set them in contrast with other processes, as language or social structure, translating or coexisting dynamics of the material and immaterial. The “in between states” of the territory of the Netherlands, not solid, not liquid, always dealing with artifice to allow inhabiting became a major subject in the work joining the physical and the social state of this territory. This work perceives and correlates dynamics of the living and the inert, the anthropic and the natural, the soil and the social, deeply interwoven in the latitude.

The logic of geological strata serve as sediment to a body of work sceptical to anthropocentrism but open to human capacity to transform reality into more relative states. This work is an immediate consequence of that reading of society. Zechstein Sea is fruit of a long, on-going, collaboration with the company Akzo Nobel that led me to develop a whole project at their salt extraction facilities in Hengelo.

Together with the company we dug and obtained a thirty-meter long drilling from a 300.000 million years old dried sea positioned under the Netherlands, Germany and part of Denmark and England. That sea is now a solid block of salt buried 400 meters under the surface. The work emphasizes the “now” in a physical and temporal way and relativizes human scale.















Pannotia

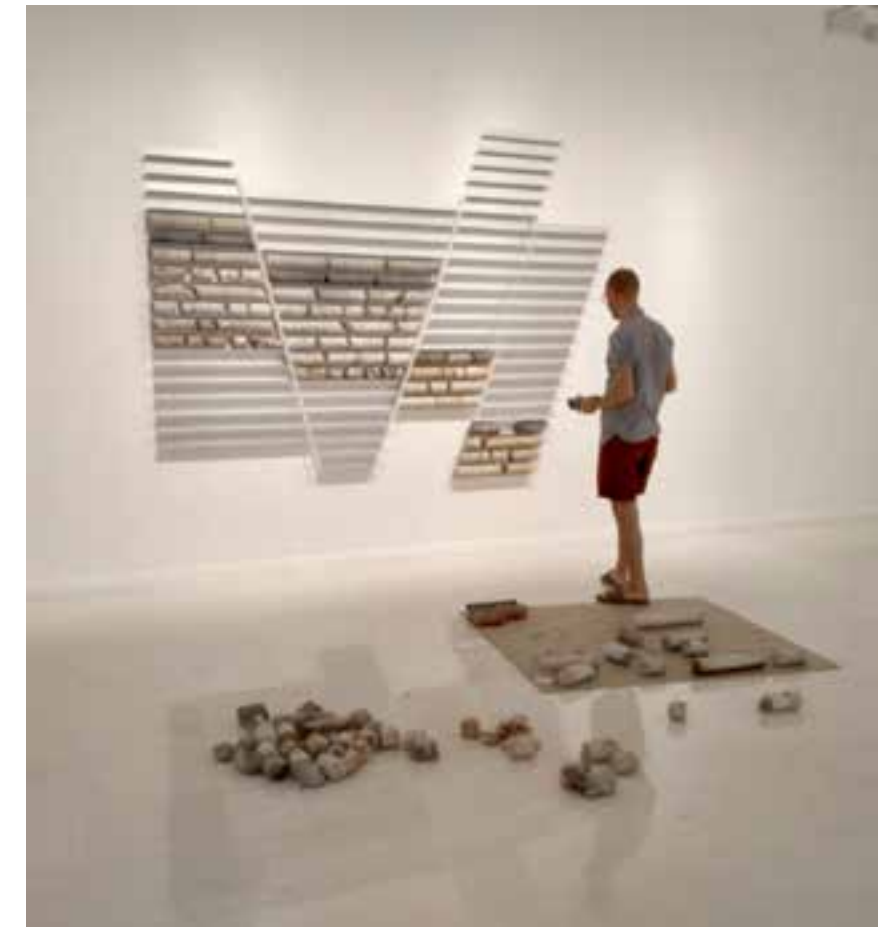
The core of my work is human -time and space- scale and his relation to the world using phenomena that precede him as well as the objects and situations generated by him. For this purpose I use geological and industrial crafts to unveil our surrounding.

This line of work deals with equilibrium and tension from regions with a rich biosphere but also populated and intervened by humans.

For Pannotia I have been studying the relation between landscapes before and after the anthropic in these regions and focused between the Precambrian and the Cambrian periods (540 million years ago) where the biggest explosion of life known on earth happened. During that time most of the earth was oceanic soil and new land emerged as a type of broome, sweeping millions of species now present in the land as sedimentary and metamorphic rocks. The coast acted as a sort of spatula compressing time and its sediments, as many geological signs show today. It was in that moment that appeared most of taxonomic and vertebrate groups we know today.

The next biggest transformation is happening since the first half of twentieth century with the intervention of Humans, transformation of landscape, emissions and residue. In my practice I operate between these parameters of time scale, perspective and recent history to unveil the geological and antropic layers of each location. In conversation with national geological centers and the local communities I try to open a conversation, reading geotechnical drillings to explain the territory and its material legacy. It is vital that through art we filter and nourish our relation with the soil we live in. This turns into a conversation, an exchange of information from the technical to the popular knowledge, involving geologists, geographists, philosophers and artists in conjunction with the inhabitants of the area to construct new narratives of stratification and consciousness about our footprint on earth.

















Walls

Walls, series started in Basque country and continued in the Colombian jungle of Tolima. The work reacts to the way in which the human being cuts through territory and existing orography, in the case of highways in the Basque Country it shows a vertical cut that unveils the flowing dynamics of geology, in the case of the jungle, it opens roads for traffic and the jungle reacts and takes over them in a matter of hours. Flowing is not a unique quality of liquid, and no only liquids flow. In this series two dynamics collide and what remains is an open wound.

In the case of Colombian jungle, the importance of this reordering of the landscape is vital because it refers to a geopolitical issue that is experienced there. The way in which other communicating infrastructures such as the railway, which until the middle of the twentieth century was the most important mean of modern transport, has been disfavored until it disappeared due to the imposition of oil companies. The traffic of goods by road causes fatal accidents continuously and shows the inadequacy of both rhythms. Walls unfolds in image and formal solution that constant in my work of certain imbalance, bankruptcy or fault between "human tempo" and "natural tempo". A body of work skeptical to anthropocentrism but longing for the human capacity to transform reality into better possibilities.













High Tides

The World is already full and does not contain us.

Saint Jerome.

One must go back some three centuries to the geological discovery of deep time, of the actual thickness of our planet, at the end of the 17th century, to pinpoint the origins of a change of paradigm, a leap in historical perspective from 6.000 years to 4.500 million years. That sudden expansion of history meant our physical confrontation with the mass of time. The discovery of time matter led to the birth of the relative, the questioning of the now, in relation to dimension and scale.

This research focuses on Urdaibai, a territory located in the Basque Country, which was declared a Biosphere Reserve in 1984, an event that stands as a cut, a change of perspective for a specific domain. A thin superficial change in history, not in political or social but in geographical terms, a measurement of time where all interventions on a human scale are blurred and become, for the time being, the surface.

The experience of that time turned relief, places temporal delimitations of geology, such as the Holocene[1], in relation with the Anthropocene[2], alongside contemporary time lapses closer to our scale such as the weather, seasons, urban planning and politics might be.



The project relies on natural and artificial processes for a parallel analysis of geological and social structures of development. For instance: how a process of sedimentation or mineral crystallisation can visually embody processes of maturation, evolution and social cohesion. Or conversely: how a volcanic composition with characteristic effervescent cavernous formations, developed rapidly over time (fast crystallisation), can suggest similarities on a formal plane with, say, a revolution.

The title High Tides points to this relation between times, to the minimal but constant intervention of now, of the present and its representation. Lapses such as the lunar cycle or the tides, which more or less imperceptibly influence an existing medium depending on the perspective one has toward what is unfolding.

High Tides consists on the relativisation of structures and processes of evolution. States of matter are only partly solid or liquid, or prove to be generalisations about more complex states. The anthropocentric in its relation to territory suffers from a similar lack of perspective, or from what Virilio calls grey ecology.

Both the 17th century cut and that of 1984 are notches in a space-time continuum of objective reality, and their connotations, be they positive or negative, will depend upon the readings or interventions that might be applied to them. Here we are handling the gap between both moments, from the entry of a new agent into the layer dynamics, until this agent (ourselves) becomes self-aware, as stratum and as critical space.

Substance is what it is and accident what takes place. Whether it is a strata cut or an apple falling, the accident lets us know its substance, it unveils its qualities in relation with the time line. Something similar happens with us as accidents, as active agents that represent the beginning of a stratum with its own consciousness. In Urdaibai there is a possibility (though not the concrete fact) of human action as a constructive agent that is perhaps not additive, subtractive or fluctuating like the tides; but above all, self-aware.

“Exoticism is everything that is other”, said Victor Segalen. That other is simply beneath, it is the endotic. Tropical Euskadi is underneath; the place where our feet stand is at once volcano, reef, and submarine valley. What a new entry into this stratigraphic construction contains, as it is now, is the precise quality of not yet having been written.

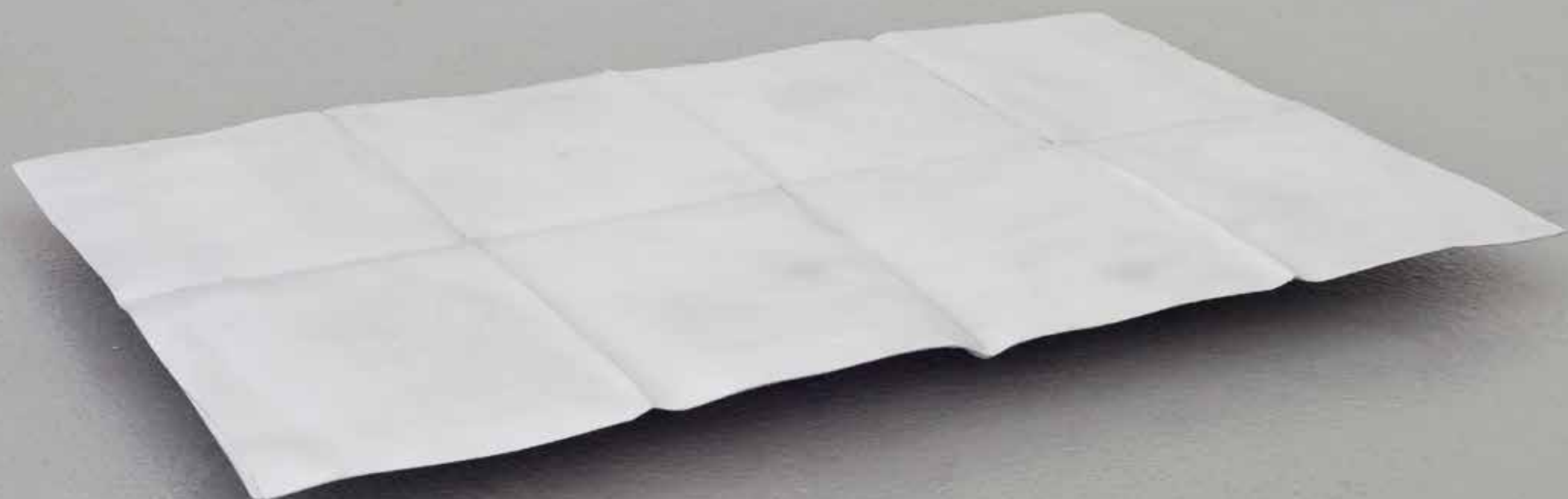
Carlos Irijalba. Urdaibai, 2012

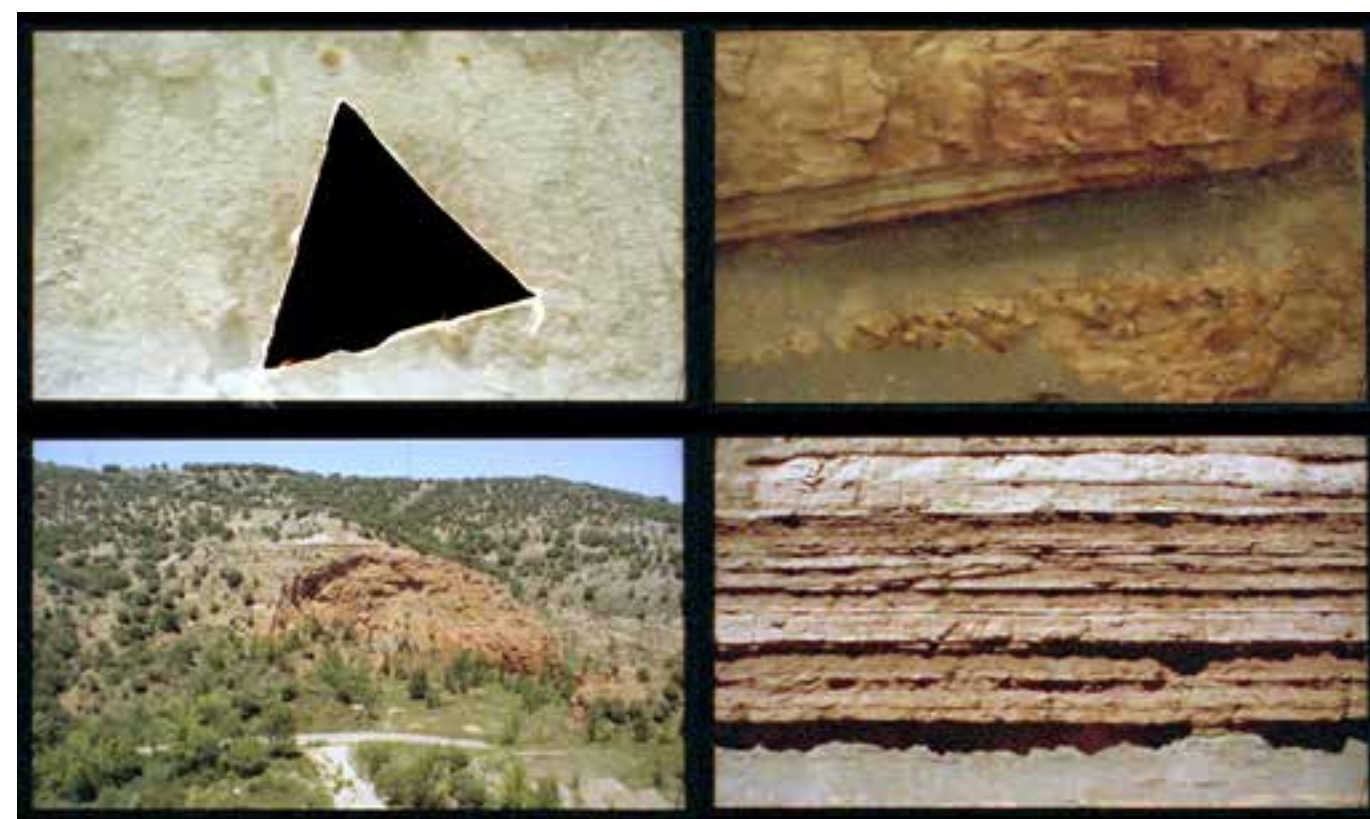
Carlos Irijalba. Urdaibai, 2012

[1] The last phase of the Quaternary Period that stretches from 11,700 years ago to the present day and coincides with the end of the last glaciation.

[2] Term used to describe the present period in the Earth's history since human activity had a significant global impact.











Carlos Irijalba -1979- Pamplona (Spain). Lives and works in New York.

Academic background/ Residencies

- 2013/14 - Rijksakademie van beeldende kunsten. Amsterdam.
- 2009 - ISCP Program New York.
- 2004 - UDK: Universität der Kunst. Prof. Lothar Baumgarten. Berlin.
- 2003 - Graduated in Fine Arts at the Basque Country University. Bilbao.
- 1998 - Bachelor degree at the Pamplona School of Art. Pamplona

Exhibitions (selection)

- 2021
 - Joined an avalanche, never to be alone again. Solo exhibiton at Tale of a Tub curated by Julia Gerlings, Rotterdam (Netherlands).
 - **Ω** Omega Group exhibition curated by Gabriel Lester at ElectriciteitsFabriek Den Haag (Netherlands).
 - Shanghai Biennale. Bodies of water. Power Station of Art (Shanghai, China) Curated by You Mi, Andres Jaque and Marina Otero.
 - And the wall became allergic to humans. Three solo exhibitons: Altamira Museum, Biblioteca Central de Cantabria and Juan Silió Gallery (Cantabria, Spain)
 - Via Tópica. Fundacion Maria Forcada (Tudela, Spain).
 - Cronografias. Curated by Juan Bautista Peiró. Fundación Mediterraneo. (Alicante, Spain)
- 2020
 - Bajo la Superficie. Curated by Javier Martin-Jimenez. Centro Conde Duque. (Madrid)
 - Cronografias. Fundacion Mediterraneo (Valencia)
 - The essential Goods Show. Fisher Parrish Gallery (New York, United States)
 - Extemporáneo. Solo show. Museo de Navarra. (Pamplona)
 - Una dimensión Ulterior. Museo Patio Herreriano (Valladolid)
 - Cielos Abiertos. CDAN Centro de Arte y Naturaleza (Huesca)
 - Escap ES Centro Cultural Galileo. (Madrid)
- 2019
 - Premio internacional Maria Jose Jove. (A Coruña)
 - Atracción y resistencia. Curated by Rosario Sarmiento and Alberto Cartón Centro de exposiciones Pallexco. (Galicia)
 - 25 años de Itinerarios. Botin Art Center Santander.(Cantabria)
- 2018
 - Endotic. Galeria Moises Perez de Albeniz. (Madrid)
 - Region (narratives) Changes in the landscape and the politics of water Curated by Alfredo Puente and Bruno Marcos at MUSAC Museo (León)
- 2017
 - Guangzhou Triennale Curated by Zeng Han and Bao Dong. Guangdong Museum of Contemporary Art. (China)
 - Notes on our equilibrium. Curated by Evelyn Simons and Eleonore de Sadeleer at CAB Art Center Brussels (Belgium).
 - Art on the turn of the century” curated by Benjamin Weil at Centro Botin Santander (Spain).
 - A Myriad of voices. Curated by La fabrica. DC Cultural Center. Washington D.C. and Miami (USA)
- 2016
 - Race to the bottom. Curated by Joram Kraaijeveld Schloss Ringenberg. Hamminkeln (Germany)
 - 1513 desde las paces de Urtubia. Museo Jorge Oteiza. Alzuza (Spain)
 - Reproductibilidad. Curated by Nekane Aranburu. Es Baluard Museum (Spain)
- 2015
 - Concrete. Curated by Geraldine Barlow. Tophane-i Amite Culture and Arts Center. Istanbul (Turkey).
 - Invincible forest. Curated by Annie Le Brun Museum of Contemporary Art. Zagreb.

- Skins. Galeria Moises Perez de Albeniz. Madrid.
- Percussive Hunter. Curated by Niekolaas Johannes Lekkerkerk. Akbank Sanat arts Center. Istanbul.
- Listen to the stones, think like a mountain. Curated by Evelien Bracke. Galerie Tatjana Pieters. Ghent.

- 2014
 - Open Studios at Rijksakademie. Amsterdam.
 - Out there. Curated by Bart van den Boom. Rotterdam.
 - Concrete. Curated by Geraldine Barlow. MUMA Museum, Melbourne.
 - Lost in Landscape. Curated by Gerardo Mosquera. MART Trento.
 - Insights into the Wemhöner Collection. OSRAM Höfe, Berlin.
 - Artists’ Film at Carroll/Fletcher, London.
 - Amalgam. Solo show curated by Julia Geerlings. Galerie Van Gelder. Amsterdam.
- 2013
 - Projections Art Rotterdam. Rotterdam Netherlands.
 - Coleccion VIII CA2M. Madrid.
 - L’Comme Lumière. Gaitè Lirique. Paris
 - High Tides. Galerie Sherin Najjar. Berlin.
- 2012
 - Delimitations. Curated by Ghila Limon. Herzliya Museum Israel.
 - Lost sites. Curated by Teresa Blanch. Centro Huarte. Spain.
 - Urban Projections Yokohama Art Center. Japan.

Prizes/Grants

- 2020
 - Artist book prize Ankaria Foundation. (Spain)
- 2017
 - Mondriaan Fonds Bewezen Talent (Netherlands)
- 2013/14 - Rijksakademie van beeldende kunsten. Amsterdam.

Bibliography (selection)

- *Speculative materialism and geoaesthetics in the era of the anthropic*. By Paul Hobson. Caniche Editorial 2021.
- *A rock turns into a frog*, Stefanie Hessler Caniche editorial 2021

Work held on public collections (selection):

- Sammlung Wemhoener Foundation. Berlin.
- Taviloglu Art Collection. Istanbul.
- Rijksakademie van Beeldende Kunsten. Amsterdam.
- Museo Nacional Centro de Arte Reina Sofia. Madrid
- Ministry of Culture. Spain.

